

1. Executive Summary

The purpose of this document is to present the framework for anticipatory action (AA) in Nepal, including the forecasting trigger (the model), the pre-agreed action plans (the delivery) and the pre-arranged financing (the money). The initial framework was endorsed in 2021 for a two-year period and subsequently extended for the 2023 and 2024 monsoon seasons. This document includes modifications made in previous years and lessons learned from the 2022 activation.

The objective of this framework is to provide collective anticipatory humanitarian action to people at risk of predicted severe monsoon flooding in Nepal. The initiative will aim to provide life-saving assistance to up to 238,831 people across 15 flood-prone municipalities (“palikas”):

- In eastern Nepal: Koshi Province, Sunsari district – 4 palikas; Madhesh Province, Saptari district - 5 palikas
- In western Nepal: Lumbini Province, Bardia district – 4 palikas; Sudurpaschim Province, Kailali district - 2 palikas.

The model relies on the *Global Flood Awareness System (GloFAS)* as well as the [Government of Nepal's flood warning systems](#). To provide agencies with the maximum window of opportunity to deliver anticipatory action on a no-regrets basis, and building on the lessons learned of the 2020 anticipatory action pilot for monsoon flooding in Bangladesh, this framework relies on a two-step trigger system:

- **Stage I:** A readiness trigger based on the GloFAS forecast, that will provide a maximum of 7 days' lead time.
- **Stage II:** An action trigger based on government system's flood warning system and the GloFAS forecast, that will provide anywhere from 3 hours to 3 days' lead.

Given that this framework targets two major river basins in Nepal, which are not linked, there are separate trigger systems for each river basin: one for the Karnali (in western Nepal) and one for the Koshi Basin (in eastern Nepal).

The delivery of anticipatory action is time-sensitive. Four UN agencies – FAO, UNFPA, UNICEF, and WFP – in partnership with the Nepal Red Cross Society (NRCS), national and local NGOs and in close collaboration with the federal, provincial and local government and district authorities, will:

- **Distribute multi-purpose digital cash payments:** Over US\$3 million will be transferred to vulnerable flood-prone households to meet their essential needs. WFP and UNICEF will provide 15,000 Nepalese Rupees per household. UNFPA will provide small digital cash top-ups to women and girls to facilitate access to obstetrics care and gender-based violence services.
- **Provide in-kind assistance:** To complement the digital cash assistance, UN agencies will provide households with essential items to mitigate the potential impacts of the flood. UNICEF will distribute hygiene kits, water purification tablets, jerry cans, buckets and mugs and will install emergency toilets in evacuation centers. UNFPA will distribute dignity kits and reproductive health kits. FAO will provide hermetic bags for waterproof storage of grains and seeds.
- **Deliver services:** The framework provides an opportunity to deploy trained personnel to provide important gender-inclusive services to potential flood-affected households at evacuation sites and other assembly points. UNFPA and its partners will deploy community psychosocial workers and female community health volunteers to promote sexual and reproductive health as well as gender-based violence services. UNICEF will deploy trained community psychosocial workers. Agencies and their partners will also provide early warning messages to vulnerable households.

The money for the framework comes from different sources, mainly from the Central Emergency Response Fund (CERF) of up to \$6.5 million. CERF financing will be released as automatically as possible immediately once the defined triggers

are reached *in each river basin*. The pre-arranged financing agreement with CERF is in place for one severe flooding event per river basin until the end of 2024.

2. Introduction

Objectives of anticipatory action

There is broad agreement on the need for the international humanitarian sector to move from a largely responsive approach to an anticipatory approach. An anticipatory approach leads to a more effective, efficient and dignified response. It also protects hard-won development gains.

Today, we can predict with increasing confidence the occurrence and humanitarian impact of certain climate- and weather-related shocks. By combining different analytical approaches, out-of-the-ordinary weather events can not only be predicted, but their projected impact can proactively be mitigated based on pre-identified anticipatory actions. Building on growing evidence that acting prior to the onset of a predictable hazard is significantly more (cost-)effective than traditional humanitarian response, OCHA has facilitated the setup of multiple Anticipatory Action frameworks.

Each framework comprises 3 core elements, all of which are underpinned by a clear learning, monitoring and evaluation plan:

- A robust forecasting embedded in a clear decision-making process (the **model**).
- Pre-agreed action plans that can fundamentally alter the trajectory of the crisis (the **delivery**).
- Pre-arranged finance (the **money**).

Anticipatory action is still an innovative space, requiring “proof of concept”. Thus, in addition to the 3 core elements, OCHA also invests in documenting evidence and learning from each framework.



Core principles

Each anticipatory action framework is tailored to the local context. OCHA has identified nine core principles for the framework in Nepal:

- **Prioritizing a multi-sectoral approach:** Partners should prioritize multi-sectoral, co-targeted interventions when possible to maximize synergies and to achieve great impact.
- **Ensuring the centrality of protection:** In line with the IASC centrality of protection policy, and the principle of “leaving no one behind” (2030 Agenda), all partners implementing anticipatory interventions have the responsibility to ensure that their response will not aggravate the exposure of communities to risks of violence, insecurity, extortion and exploitation. Anticipatory actions must also ensure that they benefit all communities (local communities, displaced communities, returnees, and refugees) based on their needs, with due attention given to obstacles linked to gender, age, disability or social affiliation.
- **Promoting accountability to affected populations:** Partners engaged in the implementation of the anticipatory action framework are responsible for the integration of accountability to affected populations approaches in their activities. This includes making all efforts to solicit, hear, and act upon the voices and priorities of affected people (including the most marginalized and at-risk women, men, girls and boys) in a coordinated manner, before, during,

and after anticipatory action. It also means ensuring that community feedback leads to corrective action in future anticipatory action.

- **Supporting localization:** All partners involved in the implementation of this framework are expected to honour the HCT's commitment towards localization. Equitable partnerships with local actors building upon their long-term relationships and trust with communities during anticipatory action are crucial.
- **Engaging in partnerships:** Collaboration across humanitarian actors is key to ensuring that all sectors are engaged, and that assistance is mobilized according to the AA framework.
- **Using cash where possible:** OCHA encourages the use of cash as the default assistance modality where markets and operational contexts permit.
- **Generating development co-benefits:** Framework participants are encouraged to consider how financing for anticipatory action can complement financing for development by reducing suffering and addressing the root causes of problems. For instance, if the pre-agreed anticipatory action plan includes the repair of boreholes, implementing agencies should ensure that the quality of the repairs will last beyond the immediate humanitarian crisis.
- **Capturing learning:** Monitoring, evaluation and learning activities should be embedded at every phase of the development and implementation of the AA framework.
- **Striving for integration:** The framework seeks to integrate the anticipatory action activities into the existing humanitarian architecture and to foster linkages with long term programming, including resilience and development initiatives.

Alignment with Government Policy

The AA framework for Nepal is prepared in consultation with the Government of Nepal, Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA), and relevant line Ministries (especially government cluster leads) for the different activities. It follows on ongoing discussions from the National and Regional Anticipatory Action Dialogue Platforms, and builds on national, regional and global good practices. The AA framework will continue to evolve in line with the Government of Nepal's disaster act, policies, framework, guidelines etc. including the Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Rules, 2076 (2019) and with future policy, including National Early Action Protocols (NEAPs) and other tools. The long-term goal is to support the integration of Anticipatory Action into local and national systems for disaster risk reduction and management, such as shock-responsive safety nets, to produce sustainable approaches to AA for the range of hazards, including climate adaption. Lessons learned from the implementation of this AA framework and related activities should form the basis for ongoing discussions with the Government on the development of policies to shape and guide AA initiatives in the future.

Monsoon flooding in Nepal

Exposure

One of Nepal's three geographical zones, the flat plains of the Terai areas, is at the highest risk of flooding during the monsoon season. Monsoon rains typically lead to landslide damming, excessive erosion of hill slopes, and rock falls in the country's two other geographical zones: the Hill and Mountain areas¹.

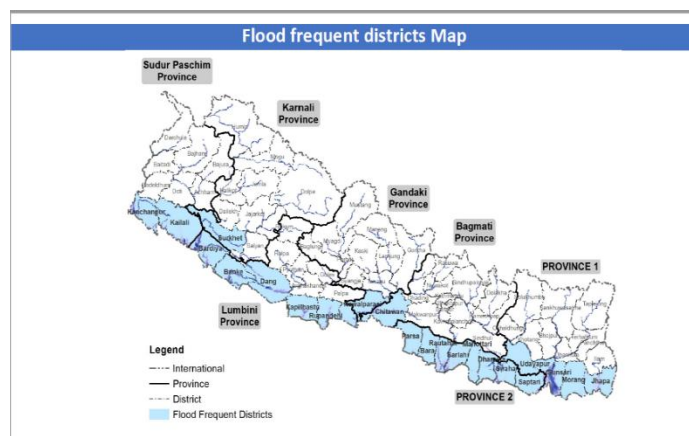
¹ UN, Nepal: Monsoon Emergency Response Preparedness Plan 2020 (2020).

Vulnerability

CERF-funded Anticipatory Action frameworks should be needs-based. They are encouraged to identify those groups that are especially vulnerable to the specific shock that is being anticipated, and should prioritize groups such as women, girls, persons with disabilities, and persons in need of protection assistance.

Humanitarian impact

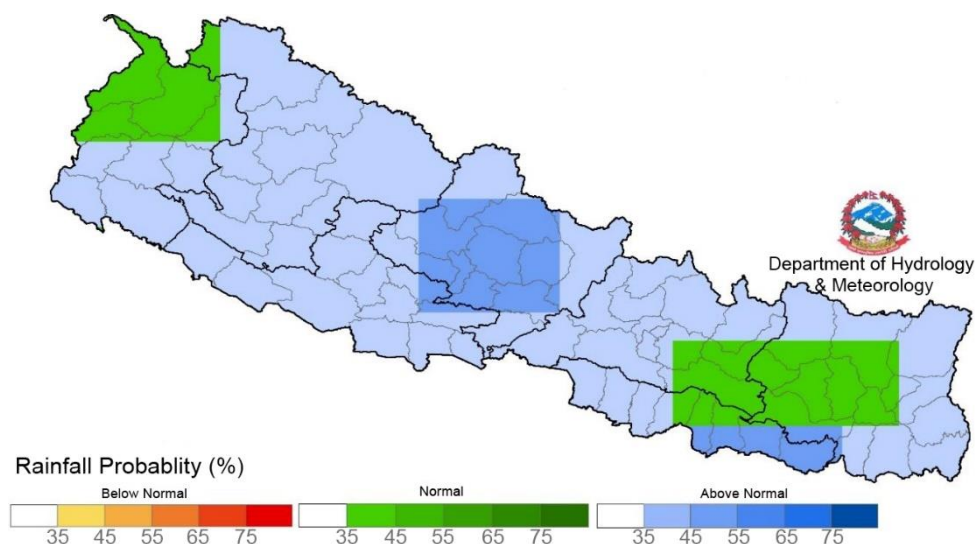
In 2017, monsoon floods affected some 1.7 million people in the Terai, including 460,000 who were displaced. Economic losses were estimated at US\$705M. The flooding impacted 35 of the country's 75 districts, with the Ministry of Home Affairs reporting at the time that over 80 per cent of the land in the Terai – Nepal's breadbasket – was inundated.



Since 2006, CERF has allocated US\$59.5M to Nepal, including US\$13.5M for rapid responses to floods.² In October 2022 predicted severe flooding in western Nepal led to a full activation of this framework and the disbursement of US \$3.2M from CERF, enabling UNFPA, UN Women, WFP and their partners to distribute digital cash payments, comprehensive relief packages (food and non-food items, energy saving cooking device, solar radio, clothes) and hygiene, dignity and health kits; and to deliver services such as psycho-social counseling.

Flood typically affects the districts along the length of Nepal's southern border (See Figure).

Seasonal forecast for 2024



The Government of Nepal's Department of Hydrology and Meteorology has forecasted the 2024 monsoon season from **June 1 to September 30, 2024**. Below are the key details of the forecast:

Overall Monsoon Outlook: Most of the country will experience above-normal rainfall, with a probability ranging from 35% to 55%.

² CERF funded flood responses in 2008 (US\$3.6M), 2014 (US\$1.9M), 2017 (US\$4.8M), 2022 (\$3.2)

Provincial Outlook:Normal Monsoon (Probability 35%-45%):

- Few areas in the northwest of Sudur Paschim Province.
- Southeast area of Bagmati Province.
- Mid-area of Madhesh Province.
- Mid and mid-west region of Koshi Province.

Above-Normal Monsoon (Probability 55%-65%):

- Mid-region of Gandaki Province.
- Southeast region of Madhesh Province.

In summary, the majority of Nepal is expected to experience above-normal rainfall during the monsoon season, with specific regions having varying probabilities of normal and above-normal monsoon conditions.

3. Forecast and Trigger

Triggers and thresholds

A trigger for anticipatory action should be based on a set of criteria to help answer the questions when and where to act before an imminent disaster. It should forecast when a hazard risks becoming an out-of-the-ordinary (or severe) shock and the humanitarian impact is likely to cross a certain threshold for the exposed vulnerable community.

There are two main challenges in developing a trigger for flooding: typically flood models can only provide a maximum of 2-3 weeks of advance warning, and there is an inverse correlation between the reliability of flood warnings and the amount of warning time (i.e., the earlier the warning, the less reliable it tends to be).

Additionally, the development of a two-step trigger system³ for the Nepal AA framework is more complex than in, for example, the Bangladesh AA pilot for several of reasons. Firstly, Nepal's mountainous terrain means that flood forecasting models struggle for lead times above a few days. Secondly, while water levels can be used to define historical flood events, the link between water levels and impact has not yet been clearly established. Finally, the framework plans to target multiple major river basins in Nepal, which are not linked. This initiative therefore relies on separate systems: one for the Karnali Basin (in western Nepal) and one for the Koshi Basin (in eastern Nepal).

To provide agencies with the maximum window of opportunity for funding to be disbursed in time for agencies to deliver anticipatory action on a no-regrets basis, and building on the lessons learned from earlier AA project as well as the Bangladesh monsoon flooding AA pilot, the Nepal framework relies on a two-step trigger system **for each basin system** (see page 7 for basin-specific thresholds):

- **Stage I:** A readiness trigger based on the GloFAS⁴ forecast, that will provide a maximum of 7 days' lead time ahead of peak flooding.
- **Stage II:** An action trigger based on Nepal Government, Department of Hydrology and Meteorology's River Watch system and the GloFAS forecast, that will provide anywhere from 3 hours to 3 days' lead time.

Readiness Trigger	Action Trigger		
GloFAS 7-day forecast predicts 70% probability of reaching 1-in-2-year return period	Flood warning bulletin issued by the Government of Nepal's Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM)		
	+		
	GloFAS 3-day forecast predicts 70% probability of reaching 1-in-2 year return period	OR	Water level reaches government-defined danger level (3-hour warning only)

The GloFAS river discharge 1-in-2 year return period was selected after the analysis of the GloFAS forecast skill revealed that the model tends to underestimate observed river discharge. For this reason, a 1-in-2 year return period threshold applied to a 70% forecast confidence actually corresponds to lower frequency / higher impact events for the action trigger at Chatara (1-in-2.5 year) and both triggers at Chisapani (1-in-6 year for the action trigger). The action trigger relies on two components: the DHM flood bulletin on one hand and the GloFAS 3-day forecast or government-based observational data on the other. The use of DHM bulletins ensures that the framework is only activated for high impact events.

The GloFAS model is able to capture only between 30% and 70% of the high impact events recorded in the past. In order to deal with this limitation, the action trigger also includes a real-time water level component. While this only provides a few hours of warning, this information will nevertheless improve the quality of the trigger system by reducing the likelihood of missing any major events.

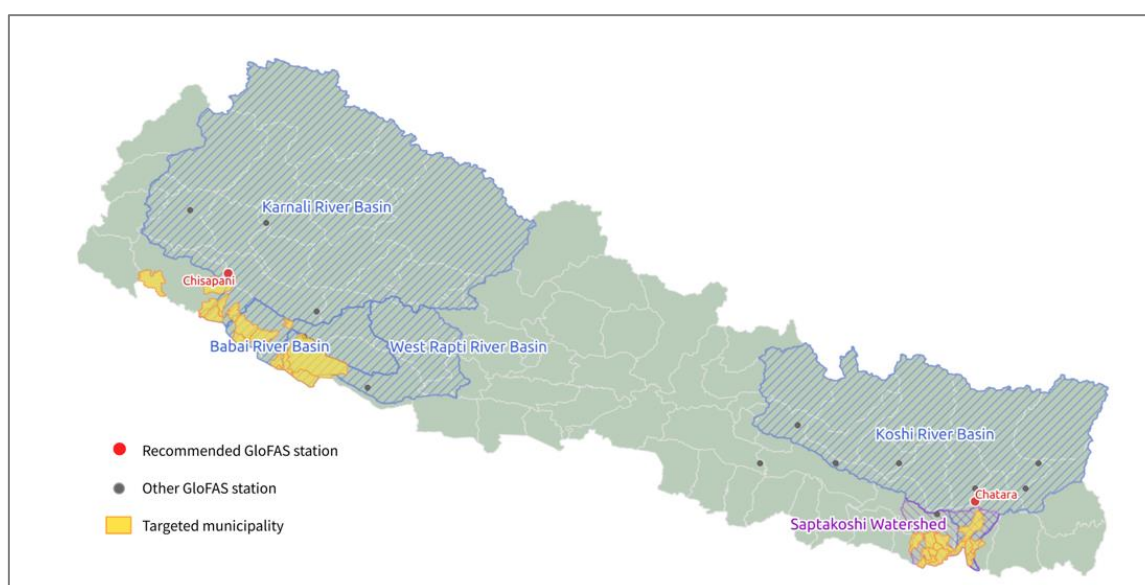
³ Consisting of a 'readiness' trigger to launch a set of preparatory activities and an 'action' trigger to launch the delivery of assistance to people at risk.

⁴ The Global Flood Awareness System (GloFAS), implemented by the European Commission, is designed to support preparatory measures for flood events worldwide, particularly in large trans-national river basins. GloFAS combines information from satellites, models and in-situ measurements. <https://www.globalfloods.eu/>

However, as with all trigger systems, there are limitations. Due to the challenging nature of forecasting river discharge in Nepal, only a fraction of GloFAS 1-in-2 year return period exceedance events are expected to be correctly forecasted with 4-7 days lead time. **The implication for the project is that this model/mechanism has a non-negligible probability of reaching the action trigger directly without a readiness trigger first.** This will not impact the amount of funding that CERF will release, nor will it affect the plan of pre-agreed activities; some of these activities will simply have to be implemented once the flooding has already started.

The RCO will coordinate and engage with the relevant government agencies and technical partners to make better use of available national forecast models and other dataset, to reduce the model forecast biases.

River Basin	Karnali (WEST)	Koshi (EAST)
Station that will be monitored using GloFAS	Chisapani	Chatara
GloFAS forecast skill	Moderate to very poor for low, moderate, and extreme values (15 to 80% error)	Poor for low, moderate values and extreme values (>40% error)
GloFAS forecast bias	Very good. For extreme values, good to moderate with bias being between 0 to negative 20% for all lead times.	Very good to moderate, with being between 0% and 15% for all values and between 10% and 35% negative for extreme values for all lead times.
Readiness Threshold: GloFAS - River discharge m ³ /s	5700 m ³ /s	8100 m ³ /s
Return period	1-in-2 year	1-in-2 year
Action Threshold: GloFAS - River discharge m ³ /s	5700 m ³ /s	8100 m ³ /s
Return period	1-in-2 year	1-in-2 year
Action Threshold: DHM – water danger level	10.5 m at Chisapani river station	7.0 m at Chatara river station



Roles and responsibilities in monitoring the trigger

Both the action and readiness trigger will be monitored by OCHA's Centre for Humanitarian Data and the Resident Coordinator's Office in Nepal.

Activation protocol

There are two key decision-points in the sudden-onset AA frameworks that rely on a 2-stage trigger:

- Confirming that the threshold for the readiness trigger has been reached, which will precipitate the disbursement of funds and the implementation of readiness activities.
- Confirming that the threshold for the action trigger has been reached, which will precipitate the implementation of all anticipatory activities.

CERF will disburse funds as soon as the readiness trigger is reached. As highlighted above, there is a non-negligible probability of reaching the action trigger directly without a readiness trigger first. In this event, CERF will disburse funds as soon as the action trigger is reached.

Pre-defining this activation protocol is critical in order to avoid delays, miscommunication, uncertainty or errors once the trigger threshold is reached. The Resident Coordinator's Office of Nepal, with support from OCHA's Centre for Humanitarian Data, will monitor the GloFAS model forecasts and the DHM's bulletins, and will notify the UN agencies and CERF by email immediately once the readiness and action triggers are reached (see specific steps below). Informal communication channels will be maintained to ensure adequate information sharing.

When	Who	What
From June	RCO and CHD	Monitoring of GloFAS model and DHM website
If a trigger is reached	RCO and CHD	Confirmation of trigger
If trigger is confirmed	RCO	Informs RC, CERF and UN agencies
	CERF	Sends pre-approved CERF approval letters to UN agencies

4. Anticipatory Action Plan

Selection criteria

Anticipatory actions will aim to interrupt the pathways outlined in the crisis timeline section above by targeting populations most at risk of being impacted by a shock. The following criteria were applied to select actions:

1. **Anticipatory character:** Is the action effective in preventing or reducing the humanitarian impact of the shock?
2. **Ability to deliver within the window of opportunity:** Is it possible to carry out the action effectively with the available forecast lead time, i.e., in the window of opportunity?
3. **Operational capacity:** Do the agency and its IPs have the institutional capacity (thematic, logistic, administrative, financial, human resources) to implement the action effectively given the lead time and scale?
4. **No regrets approach:** In the case of a false alarm, will the proposed actions benefit rather than negatively the targeted population?

Priority interventions

The pre-agreed actions will focus on the following core objectives:

- **Distributing multi-purpose cash:** Providing cash assistance is an appropriate and impactful modality given the very short window of opportunity between the readiness trigger and the peak of floods.
- **Communicating risks, engaging with communities, and messaging:** Clusters have emphasized the importance of disseminating joint early warning signals as well as sector-specific messaging.
- **Providing in-kind assistance:** A limited set of in-kind assistance activities that can be mobilized within the very short window of opportunity will complement the cash transfers.
- **Facilitating access to services:** The framework provides an opportunity to provide access to sexual and reproductive health services for pregnant and lactating women, women at risk of GBV, and survivors of GBV via conditional cash transfers. Additionally, child protection services will be facilitated.

The summary table provides a snapshot of each agency's proposed activities. Further details can be found in CERF application documents.

Summary table

Outcome	Intervention	Agency	Proposed activities
The most flood-vulnerable households are able to meet their essential needs	Multi-purpose digital cash payments	WFP	• Single MPC distribution
		UNICEF	• Single MPC distribution
The most flood-vulnerable households have improved access to WASH, sexual and reproductive health, and agricultural items	Non-food items	UNICEF	• Hygiene kits and hygiene promotion • Water purification tablets • Establishment and repair of emergency WASH facilities at evacuation centers • Jerry cans, buckets and mugs • Emergency toilets
		FAO	• Hermetic grain storage bags
		UNFPA	• Dignity kits • IARH kits
The most flood-vulnerable households are able to access essential life-saving services	Services	UNFPA	• Deployment of female community health volunteers (FCHVs) and Nepal Red Cross volunteers to promote SRH and GBV services with relevant risk communication materials • Deployment of trained community psychosocial workers in affected

			communities for psychosocial first aid and referral to GBV services • Provision of GBV services at Women Friendly Spaces • Unconditional cash assistance for pregnant women and women at risk of GBV
		UNICEF	• Deployment of community psycho-social support workers for child protection • Child protection monitoring and referral
Flood-vulnerable households receive early warning information	Risk messages	FAO, UNFPA, UNICEF, WFP	• All agencies distribute early warning signals and sector-specific information

Early warning messages

All four participating agencies will provide early warning messages to at-risk communities after the readiness and action triggers are reached.

Agency	Subject	Modality
FAO	Sector-specific messages (Agriculture)	Video through local TV channels, radio, social media, megaphones
UNFPA	Sector-specific messages (GBV, SRH)	Local radio
UNICEF	Flood warning, MPC assistance, sector-specific messages (WASH, Child Protection and behaviour change)	Local radio, Megaphones, SMS/interactive voice response (IVR)
WFP	Flood warning, MPC assistance	SMS

Targeting

The pilot projects rely on a three-stage approach to identify the most-at risk households:

- **Geographical:** Targeting is based on an overlay of flood risk (using Sentinel-1 imagery for 2017, 2019 and 2020) and socio-economic vulnerability measures including poverty, food poverty, housing condition, marginalized groups, stunting and wasting. Additionally, consultation with humanitarian organizations with extensive field-level experience on historical floods and flood response, engagement with local governments and seasonal monsoon forecast are taken into consideration for final selection of municipalities.
- **Feasibility:** The list of municipalities was refined by focusing on those areas that could be covered under either of the GloFAS-based trigger mechanisms. The priority list includes 9 municipalities covered by the trigger mechanism for the East and 6 municipalities covered by the trigger mechanism for the West⁵.

⁵ East: Barachcheta, Bhokraha Narsingh, Harinagar, Koshi, Chhinamasta, Hanumannagar Kankalini, Kanchanrup, Saptakoshi, Tilathi Koiladi. West: Geruwa, Madhuwan, Rajapur, Thakurbaba, Janaki, Tikapur

- **Household-level:** In coordination with local government at rural/municipal level, households-at-risk are identified in advance based on combination of hazard maps based on historical flood events, exposure to floods, socio-economic vulnerability of households. Vulnerability factors include:
 - the building construction type
 - the household's ability to survive on their own land production for up to 3-6 months
 - the household's dependence on agriculture and/or casual labour
 - the household's education level
 - the household's social protection status
 - female-headed households and households with persons with disabilities

UNICEF: HH selected based on vulnerabilities, who lives in the settlement along Koshi river basin, in consultation with municipalities and validated by the local government. Also, prioritizing for Landless, daily wage workers, female headed HHs, family with person with disability and under five children's families among vulnerable as per existing social protection system.

Beneficiary registration

While some of the in-kind assistance and services will be provided at evacuation sites based on the above criteria, the only way of ensuring that multi-purpose and sector-specific cash and certain in-kind assistance can be distributed to those in need in the very short window of opportunity prior to the onset of the flooding is by pre-registering households in advance.

- **WFP:** WFP will rely on its existing SCOPE database of beneficiaries. Verification and validation of the beneficiary data will be conducted in the preparedness phase, jointly with local governments and cooperating partners. Households will be identified using the community-based targeting guideline endorsed by respective Local Governments. 22,624 HHs (beneficiaries) are already registered, and the verification process is expected to be completed no later than 30 June, 2024. Beneficiaries that are not registered yet meet the targeting criteria in the selected areas will be registered jointly with local governments and cooperating partners.
- **UNICEF:** UNICEF in collaboration with local governments has prepared and updated household data and bank details of those living with high flood risks using updated government social protection registry. Beneficiaries' data is expected to complete no later than 8 July 2024.
- **UNFPA:** UNFPA will rely on the WFP database under the data sharing agreement. Additionally, based on need and selection criteria, UNFPA will collaborate with local government to identify beneficiaries, particularly GBV survivors who may not be registered.
- **FAO:** FAO will utilize the WFP database for four municipalities (Chhinmasta Rural Municipality and Hanuman Nagar Kankalini municipality of Saptari district, and Barahchhetra municipality and Harinagar Rural Municipality of Sunsari district) in accordance with a data sharing agreement. Similarly, FAO will rely on the updated database of UNICEF for Tilathikoladi municipality in Saptari district. The database will be further verified and validated with the local government and partner to ensure farming households eligible to receive the support are targeted.

Data sharing

In addition, agencies have agreed to share beneficiary information to be able to provide multi-sectoral assistance to the most vulnerable households. The following data-sharing agreements are in place: WFP will share their data with UNICEF, UNFPA and FAO. UNICEF will facilitate access to beneficiary data for FAO for the municipality of Tilathi Koladi in Saptari District.

Multi-purpose digital cash payments

Two UN agencies will distribute multi-purpose cash, targeting different municipalities. The transfer value for households will be the same (15,000 rupees per household), though the transfer modalities vary based on the agencies' pre-existing capabilities and operations. The transfer value was developed by the cash coordination group, and is equivalent to 80% of a 30-day minimum expenditure basket for a family of 5:

- **WFP:** WFP will rely on the remittance model, considering the operational challenges of delivering assistance within the short window of opportunity, beneficiary access to remittance agents and overall procedure for claiming the entitlement by beneficiaries. With this modality, WFP uses a pre-existing agreement with Western Union (WU) that has a wide network of remittance agents across the intervention areas. The previously foreseen domestic remittance option is no longer available due to change in the government's regulations. Additionally, Reasonable Accommodation (RA) will be ensured to access entitlement based on the RA requests received from the needy beneficiaries, particularly from persons with disabilities, pregnant and breastfeeding women and girls, and elderly. Once the action trigger is reached, beneficiaries will receive a transaction reference number / slip in order to claim their entitlement at the nearest remittance agent. Early warning messages, as well as notifications from local authorities and cooperating partners will complement the message from the financial service provider (FSP).
- **UNICEF:** UNICEF will engage with local governments in implementing the readiness and action trigger activities and draw the lessons to institutionalize this framework. UNICEF will transfer funds to the local government's bank account once the readiness trigger is reached. The local government will then authorize the banks to deposit the cash into the bank accounts of the targeted households immediately after the action trigger is reached. A SMS will be sent to the beneficiaries informing that they will be receiving multipurpose cash and a second SMS when the cash is deposited into their account. A small percentage of households who do not have bank accounts will be receiving the cash support through cash camps to be managed by the local governments.

Ensuring readiness for a timely implementation

All agencies participating in this framework confirm their readiness to implement activities as soon as a trigger is reached. Agency-specific preparedness plans are outlined below,

UNFPA

UNFPA Nepal has experience in emergency preparedness and humanitarian response, helping the identification of risks and the implementation of anticipatory actions. UNFPA has a sub-national presence with provincial offices in Province-1, 2, Lumbini, and Sudurpaschim. Collaborations with longstanding partners such as the Nepal Red Cross Society (NRCS) and Women's Rehabilitation Centre (WOREC) ensure swift mobilization of early action efforts in gender-based violence (GBV) and humanitarian response sectors during crises. Furthermore, UNFPA has strategically positioned emergency supplies in six different locations and maintains long-term standby agreements with vendors for immediate procurement of essential kits. Collaboration with federal, provincial, and local governments, alongside district disaster management committees and implementing partners, underscores UNFPA's commitment to preparedness and response efforts. Through its provincial offices and implementing partners, UNFPA completes a range of preparedness activities ahead of triggers and establishes necessary operational arrangements for early action.

UNICEF

UNICEF has a long history of working in emergency preparedness and humanitarian contexts, with all three tiers of government and humanitarian partners at different levels from federal to local levels including local NGOs with whom UNICEF has a long-standing partnership. UNICEF has prepositioned emergency supplies including WASH sector for approximately 10,000 households in five strategic locations of the country, one of those, nearby to the east river basin which is part of this programme. In addition, UNICEF will also preposition supplies with local NGO for targeted municipalities under the CERF AA once the readiness trigger activates. UNICEF maintains a roster of psycho-social counsellors who could be quickly deployed in the project locations upon readiness trigger and or action trigger.

FAO

Since 2015, FAO has been dedicated to developing anticipatory action capacities globally, regionally, and at the country level. Specifically in Asia, FAO has implemented anticipatory action through the activation of protocols in countries such as Bangladesh, Mongolia, the Philippines, and Viet Nam, accompanied by return-on-investment studies to gather evidence.

Since 2023, FAO has been actively investing in and contributing to the anticipatory action realm in Nepal, leveraging insights from these experiences in the Asia-Pacific region. FAO is collaborating with DPNet, Agriculture knowledge centers and rural municipalities along with the PUNOs to timely implement and deliver the planned activities during readiness and action phase. FAO has already prepositioned the supplies like grain and seeds storage bags to cover 5000 households that will be prepositioned and mobilized during the readiness and action phase respectively for the CERF AA for Koshi river basin. Likewise, FAO will be disseminating risks communication messages in agriculture, livestock and fisheries to protect the agricultural livelihoods of the farming communities at risk of floods.

WFP

The overall intervention design reflects WFP's experiences with anticipatory action approaches gathered since 2015, as well as lessons learnt from the 2022 anticipatory cash intervention in Lumbini and Sudur-Paschim provinces. This has enabled identification of key risks, challenges and corresponding mitigation/ prevention measures to ensure timely implementation of the proposed anticipatory intervention. A number of preparatory activities need to be conducted before the triggers are reached, covering policy/guidelines around anticipatory interventions, institutional set up and operational/institutional arrangements. The implementation of anticipatory cash assistance at scale requires close coordination with local governments, and cooperating partners with extensive experience in disaster response. WFP has been working with the SEBAC and NEEDS Nepal, the proposed cooperating partner for the implementation of the anticipatory action plan, and with relevant government agencies at municipal, district, provincial and federal level to facilitate this process. The cooperation includes the policy/ guideline framework, SOPs for anticipatory cash assistance, early warning dissemination protocols, verification of beneficiaries, distribution plan and monitoring & evaluation. Operational arrangements critical for implementation of anticipatory cash intervention and early warning dissemination that need to be conducted before the trigger is met include a range of activities related to consolidation of beneficiary lists. This includes verification of beneficiary data for the beneficiaries that are already included in the SCOPE database, and possible registration of additional beneficiaries in the selected areas in case these beneficiaries meet the pre-determined criteria. The community-based targeting guideline has been endorsed across the Local Governments to facilitate targeting process through direct engagement of community disaster management committee in the selection, verification and prioritization process. As part of WFP's technical assistance to the Local Governments, WFP has been supporting in setting-up pre-disaster risk assessment tools to introduce impact-based forecasting and warning services for identifying cluster-specific needs and design of pre-emptive actions including activation of AA-based contingency plans. These activities will be done by the cooperating partners jointly with the municipal governments.

Lessons from previous activations

WFP

WFP has prior experience of delivering anticipatory action / forecast-based financing in Nepal. WFP has identified the following lessons:

- Weather forecasting has its inherent level of uncertainty, highlighting the importance of the "no regrets" principle for anticipatory approaches.
- A suitable cash transfer mechanism is critical to ensure the effectiveness of anticipatory cash assistance.
- Government engagement at all levels is essential along with other DRR stakeholders to ensure enabling environment for anticipatory approaches.
- Further advocacy around the benefits of anticipatory approaches at the local level would benefit the overall adoption of anticipatory approaches at scale and as a sustainable DRR approach.
- Standby agreements with Financial Service Partners with well-advance information sharing of objectives and expected outcomes largely overcome the hurdle in delivering cash. However, limited human and technical resources in the field of FSPs presented major challenges. Without support from Cooperating Partners in registering 'Know-Your-Customer' forms and active engagement of local government, including physical presence of staffs and provision items such as camera, photocopy machine, timely registration and withdrawal of cash assistance would not have been feasible.
- Timely issuance of Letter of Authorization with pre-deposits of cash in FSP's bank account is imperative as cash transfer between implementing agency and FSP takes around maximum 24 hours. In anticipatory cash assistance, each hour counts in transferring the cash to beneficiaries and making its use in purchasing essential items.
- Possible arrangements of multiple banking institutions in the implementing site is critical as it determines the success of cash transfers to beneficiaries with limited human resources of banking institutions. As Banke had only one bank, the days required for cash transfer to successfully meet the beneficiaries number was challenging and

thus distribution plan with engagement of banks started earlier and continued late. For Bardiya, three banks were available and thus, beneficiaries collected cash assistance without major problems.

- Availability of common database of potential beneficiaries that could be used to select household based on pre-specified targeting criteria.
- False alarms further amplify the challenges.

UNFPA

- Coordinating with all levels of government and like-minded organizations during preparedness to ensure smooth implementation of early actions.
- Advocating to all levels of government for anticipatory action approaches based on no-regret principles.
- Conducting a comprehensive household assessment with essential information to identify the most vulnerable and at-risk populations.
- Recognizing the risk of false alarms that may hinder early action efforts.
- Identifying female community health volunteers and Community Psychosocial workers during the preparedness phase and providing immediate orientation after readiness/action triggers to enhance rapid community outreach.
- Prepositioning items in strategic locations to ensure timely delivery of services to at-risk populations.
- Joint review with municipality authorities, UN agencies, and implementing partners to address bottlenecks.
- Mobilization of community psychosocial counsellors were found to be effective in providing psychosocial first aid.
- Update and dissemination of GBV referral pathways significantly enhanced the information on GBV prevention and response.

5. Pre-agreed Financing

CERF

The UN humanitarian chief agreed to allocate up to \$140 million from the UN's Central Emergency Response Fund (CERF) to support a series of anticipatory action frameworks.⁶ For this revised anticipatory action framework in Nepal, the ERC has agreed to allocate *up to* \$6.5 million if triggers are reached. Further details can be found in the CERF application documents.

CERF will disburse funds once three conditions are met:

- Endorsement by the relevant Resident/Humanitarian Coordinator of the country-specific Anticipatory Action framework and the CERF application package; and
- Endorsement by the Emergency Relief Coordinator of the country-specific Anticipatory Action framework and the CERF application package comprising an application chapeau; and
- Activation of the pre-agreed readiness trigger or action trigger until the end of the 2024 monsoon season

CERF will disburse funds on a no-regrets basis as soon as either the readiness trigger or the action trigger is reached. While a portion of the fund can be used immediately upon disbursement for readiness activities, the remaining portion of the funding can only be used if and when an action trigger is reached. The amount of funding for readiness vs action activities will be clearly defined in the pre-approved project proposals and budget. The need to distinguish between these two cost categories in advance is important given the different potential scenarios:

- Scenario A: all-systems go (readiness trigger followed a few days later by an action trigger)
- Scenario B: false alarm (readiness trigger, but no action trigger)
- Scenario B-2: false alarm, followed by readiness + action trigger within a maximum of 6 months
- Scenario C: action trigger, but no readiness trigger.
- Scenario D: no activation at all

Other donors

This framework for anticipatory action is not limited to CERF-funded activities. WFP will use resources mobilized through its internal trust fund for anticipatory cash transfers in a district not targeted by this anticipatory action pilot (Panchthar, Jhapa and Banke district). The same trigger mechanism and targeting criteria as proposed for the CERF-funded anticipatory action will be used, with a view to transfer anticipatory cash assistance to around 2,600 households.

UNICEF is planning to expand the blockchain modality while implementing the AA framework and other emergency cash responses.

Agency	CERF funding (in US\$)	Preparedness co-funding (in US\$)	Implementation co-funding (in US\$)	Total (in US\$)
FAO	350,000	80,000	-	430,000
UNFPA	1,261,000	320,000	-	1,581,000
UNICEF	899,000	-	100,000	999,000
WFP	3,623,000	250,000	320,000	4,193,000
	6,133,000	650,000	420,000	7,203,000

⁶ <https://www.unocha.org/story/un-humanitarian-chief-release-140m-cerf-funds-anticipatory-action-projects>

6. Learning

Monitoring & Evaluation

Each agency will use its existing monitoring & evaluation systems to collect and track data on implementation progress and outputs achieved. This can be financed through the CERF funds. All findings will be shared.

In addition, a joint Post Distribution Monitoring (PDM) will be conducted by third-party under the leadership of WFP on behalf of all participating agencies in case of a full framework activation in 2024. An independent research firm will be selected to undertake the evaluation after the action trigger is reached. All agencies agreed to share beneficiary data, within existing regulations, and commit to providing relevant inputs to support the PDM. The final PDM report along with data will be made available to all framework partners. The PDM will be done in close coordination and communication with participating agencies.